

Date: **September 15, 2026**

To: **Intergovernmental Affairs Committee**

CC: **Deborah Kafoury, Chief of Staff**

From: **Office of Government Relations**

Re: **Recommended Legislative Principles**

Board Legislative Principles

The Portland Public Schools (PPS) Board Intergovernmental Relations Committee presents these legislative principles to provide a strategic framework for the Board's engagement in the 2027 legislative session. Our primary objective is to advocate for policies and resources that directly support the district's core mission: ensuring every student has access to a rigorous education within a safe, welcoming, and inclusive environment. These principles reflect our commitment to fostering school communities where all students—regardless of background—possess the resources they need to learn, belong, and thrive.

Today, for PPS and school districts across Oregon that mission is at risk as schools are navigating an increasingly complex landscape of systemic challenges. Persistent funding shortfalls, exacerbated by inflationary pressures and the rising cost of essential services, are further complicated by the heightened social and emotional needs of our students. Additionally, broader community instability—driven by reductions in federal support programs like SNAP and Medicaid, alongside intensified immigration enforcement—places an unsustainable burden on our students, educators, and school leadership. Together, these factors are placing an enormous burden on schools and present threats to core student service and ongoing school stability. The PPS Board is committed to working alongside state leaders to address these root challenges and place schools and Oregon on a path to becoming the best in the nation.

As we work towards building the legislative agenda for the 2027 session, our work will be guided by the following priorities:

- **Provide Adequate Funding to Meet Students Needs:** State education funding continues to fall behind rising operational costs, leaving Portland Public Schools (PPS) with a projected $65

million shortfall for the 2027–28 school year. The state must partner with school districts to provide sufficient funding to prevent disruptions to classroom instruction and core student services. Funding must be available to help school districts shoulder the weight of unexpected cost increases including PERS, services for students with disabilities, and significantly increasing expenses.

- **Support for Students with Disabilities:** We seek a strengthened state partnership to ensure robust funding and support for students with disabilities. By prioritizing consistent, equitable resources and upholding critical protections, the state can help ensure that every student has the comprehensive support they need to succeed.

- **Strengthen Educator Preparation Programs:** Ensure new teachers are fully equipped with evidence-based practices to effectively address the evolving and complex needs of our students including English Language Learners and students with disabilities.

- **Defend Against Unfunded Mandates:** Ensure every new administrative or legal requirement placed on school districts is fully supported by state funding. Amid existing budget shortfalls, unfunded requirements force districts to divert resources directly away from students and classrooms. The state legislature must also examine existing mandates to identify and eliminate costly burdens that compromise instructional funding.